NewsBank inc.

Year in review - 6 San Fernando Valley moments to remember

December 30, 2018 | Los Angeles Daily News (CA)
Author: From staff reports | Section: News | 1200 Words
Page: 17
OpenURL Link

It's been said the San Fernando Valley is that bucolic place; the L.A. suburb that gets short shrift and little attention from the moving and shaking, the hustle and bustle, over the hill in downtown L.A. and the westside.

That may be true, but don't let that fool you into thinking there's little news or not much happening in this place of nearly 2 million people.

Sure, it has its slow days. We've had them in the newsroom. But in the bigger picture, the place the Kardashians call home, where "all the vampires walkin' through the Valley move west down Ventura Boulevard" (thanks, Tom Petty. We love you ...) and where a journey on the 405 or the 101 can, let's just say, test the inner depths of your soul, stuff happens in the Valley.

After all, a friendly reminder that if the San Fernando Valley were a city, it would be the fifth-largest in the United States of America, according to one recent report.

Suffice to say, 2018 was certainly not lacking for news, some of which we wish to the bottom of our hearts we never had to report.

There was tragedy beyond our worst nightmares, triumph, drama, yelling, loss, victory ... the worst and best of the human condition played itself out sometimes in stunningly short periods of time. So stunning, in fact, we're still processing it.

So, here's a look back at 2018's moments, issues, stories, that made us think, cry, smile, mad, happy:

Mass shooting at Borderline Bar & Grill

It was a college dance night at a bar in one of the safest American towns we know of.

But Marine Corp veteran Ian David Long walked into the Borderline Bar & Grill in Thousand Oaks on Nov. 7, 2018 and the nightclub turned into hell. When his shooting was over, 12 were dead, including Ventura County Sheriff's Sgt. Ron Helus. So was the shooter. Many others were injured, and a community was scarred forever.

It is true, Thousand Oaks is not the San Fernando Valley. But this singular event just up the 101 was close enough to rattle an entire world, and the communities close to the epicenter of this tragedy. It could not go unspoken here, in our memory of 2018.

Woolsey fire death and destruction

As grieving families and friends of the Borderline shooting victims were coming and going from the area's family reunification center, smoke was rising.

You could see it. You could smell it. You could hear fire engines in the distance. It wasn't enough that an unspeakable tragedy had occurred the night before. Now, fire was spreading. Two, in fact. But the big one, what became the Woolsey fire, would grow into a giant.

Starting in the Simi hills of Ventura County, it wouldn't take long before Woolsey would grow out of control and do

serious damage in Ventura and L.A. counties. That was Nov. 8. By Nov. 21, it was 100 percent contained.

But by then it had led to three deaths, destroyed 1,643 structures, damaged 364 others and charred 96,949 acres, the fire department said. Thousands had been evacuated, affecting communities across Ventura and L.A. Counties, including the western edge of the San Fernando Valley, in West Hills and Calabasas.

Officials are still seeking a cause, so stay tuned in 2019.

Politics/#MeToo meltdowns

That same week in early November, the week of the shooting and when the fires broke out, things started off busy enough in the San Fernando Valley.

The Valley played a role in Southern California Democratic candidates' sweeping success in high-profile elections for Congress and the California Legislature.

Katie Hill, 31, a homeless-services nonprofit executive, was elected over incumbent Rep. Steve Knight, R-Palmdale, to represent the House district that includes the northern edge of the Valley.

Christy Smith, a Newhall school board member, unseated Dante Acosta, R-Santa Clarita, in the state Assembly district covering much of the same area as Hill's.

The Valley felt the fallout from the #MeToo scandals that roiled California politics, and other industries. Special elections installed new state Assembly members Luz Rivas, D-North Hollywood, and Jesse Gabriel, D-Encino, to replace Raul Bocanegra and Matt Dababneh, Democrats who resigned amid sexual-misconduct scandals.

State Sen. Bob Hertzberg, D-Van Nuys, was ordered by Senate leaders to cut out his trademark hugging after women complained the hugs were unwanted.

LAUSD teachers set strike date

After nearly two years of getting nowhere in negotiations, 2018 was the year that L.A. public school teachers and their district couldn't agree on, well, anything.

Stymied over class size, salary and the rise of charter schools, and bitterly mistrustful of one another, they couldn't even agree that they agreed. That was clear as late as this month when the district's superintendent said the two sides had found agreement on a 6 percent raise for teachers and the union's president flatly denied it.

So, here we are, at the end of 2018, going into 2019, when on Jan. 10, teachers are set to go on strike for the first time in nearly 30 years. 2018, apparently, paved the way.

Homelessness didn't go away

2018 was the year when efforts to really house homeless people in L.A. ran into vocal opposition in all quarters of the city.

It was clear that in the San Fernando Valley, this debate was just as robust. As City Council members and L.A. County officials moved to find shelter, neighborhoods raised concerns over safety and quality-of-life issues.

In the meantime, even as communities complain about homelessness, the San Fernando Valley has just one year-round homeless shelter to address the immediate needs of the thousands who are living outdoors or in vehicles.

Shelters in Venice, downtown Los Angeles, Watts and South Los Angeles have already been approved or built, in response to a call by Los Angeles Mayor Eric Garcetti that at least one temporary shelter be set up in each of the

city’s 15 council districts.

All that said, there are those in local communities who are open to living near a shelter.

Stay tuned in 2019.

Settlement deal over Porter Ranch gas leak

The ripple effects of the giant natural gas leak at SoCal Gas’ Aliso Canyon facility near Porter Ranch three years ago continued be felt in 2018.

Perhaps the biggest ripple was SoCalGas’ $119.5 million settlement over the leak.

Under the deal, announced in August, SoCal Gas will pay out $119.5 million, covering claims lodged against the company over the leak.

California Attorney General Xavier Becerra, Los Angeles Mayor Eric Garcetti, City Councilman Mitch Englander, City Attorney Mike Feuer, Supervisor Kathryn Barger and other officials expressed satisfaction with the settlement, which came as the result of lawsuits brought by the city and county of Los Angeles and the state.

Under the terms, SoCalGas also will reimburse city, county and state governments for costs associated with their response to the leak, including the costs of hundreds of evacuations and state and local air quality monitoring studies.

But stay tuned. Some residents continue to be unhappy with the deal and dubious about agency actions in the wake of the leak, and lawsuits for related damages haven’t gone away.

Reporters Elizabeth Chou, Olga Grigoryants, Josh Cain, Bob Strauss, Ariella Plachta, Kevin Modesti and City Editor Ryan Carter contributed to this report.

Copyright (c) 2018 Daily News of Los Angeles

- **Citation (apa Style)**
  staff reports, F. (2018, December 30). Year in review 6 San Fernando Valley moments to remember*Daily News of Los Angeles (CA)*, p. 17. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/170A280B3768B140.